Human-Centered Theater: Overcoming Organizational Resistance to Authentic UX

Jaxen Dutta*

School of Engineering Design and Teaching Innovation, University of Ottawa, Ottawa, Ontario, Canada

September 21, 2025

Despite twenty-five years of advocacy for human-centered design principles, organizational adoption remains paradoxically limited across industries. This essay challenges conventional narratives that attribute slow implementation to organizational ignorance. Instead, it proposes that resistance reflects rational calculations about cultural transformation costs and the disruption of entrenched power structures. Through a systematic examination of design thinking's benefits, adoption barriers, and implementation strategies, this critique argues that authentic human-centered approaches face resistance due to their intensive implementation requirements rather than methodological shortcomings. While superficial "human-centered theater" allows organizations to claim user-centricity without meaningful change, authentic implementation requires fundamental shifts in organizational values and measurement systems that many leadership teams are unwilling to undertake.

Keywords: human-centered design, user experience, design thinking, organizational resistance, change management, planned obsolescence

I. INTRODUCTION

Organizational resistance to Human-Centered Design (HCD) reflects a systematic prioritization of operational efficiency over transformational User Experience (UX) methodologies, even when the evidence for design thinking's impact remains overwhelming. Research by Hogan et al. reported return-on-investment (ROI)figures as high as 9,900% for UX investments, though these figures represent best-case scenarios under optimal conditions [6]. Nevertheless, organizations consistently resist the cultural changes required for authentic UX implementation while simultaneously lamenting products that fail to meet user needs and demand costly redesigns.

When implemented authentically, HCD delivers extraordinary competitive advantages through systematic approaches to understanding user behaviour, needs, and goals [7]. As a structured process, authentic UX creates reliability across teams, provides scaffolding for continuous learning, establishes shared conceptions of project goals, and enables measurement capabilities for both throughput and quality [8]. It is a deliberate approach that encompasses all tangible and intan-

* adutt042@uOttawa.ca

gible aspects of user interaction.

II. THE PITFALLS OF HUMAN-CENTERED THEATER

Widespread organizational resistance reveals systematic implementation failures rather than limitations in the methodology itself. Most problematically, HCD often degenerates into "human-centered theater." These elaborate performances of user focus mask a fundamental disconnection from actual user needs. Corporate teams conduct extensive user research not to genuinely understand requirements, but to validate predetermined solutions and satisfy process requirements imposed by leadership teams that fundamentally misunderstand the cultural demands of user-centered design.

This emphasis on performance over authentic outcomes prioritizes procedural compliance, leading to situations where emotional language concerning desires and aspirations becomes a substitute for concrete problem-solving [9]. This phenomenon represents an insidious threat because it allows organizations to claim user-centricity while systematically ignoring users, fostering cynicism among stakeholders. Organizations frequently mistake narrow usability concerns for comprehensive UX design, implementing expensive cosmetic improvements that fail to address fundamental product-market fit.

Furthermore, the resource intensity argument against HCD often masks a deeper unwillingness to confront necessary cultural changes. Design thinking requires a fundamental transformation involving organizational structure, processes, and mindsets [3]. Yet, most organizations approach it as a mere process addition. The cross-functional collaboration required for authentic design thinking eliminates the massive inefficiencies created by siloed development processes, but it also challenges established departmental boundaries and power structures.

III. SYSTEMATIC RESISTANCE TO DESIGN EVANGELISM

Beyond internal organizational dynamics, the most fundamental barrier to UX adoption lies in entrenched business models that directly contradict user-centered principles. Planned obsolescence represents perhaps the most egregious example. This practice deliberately designs products with limited lifespans to encourage frequent replacement purchases, prioritizing manufacturer revenue over user needs [12].

Contemporary examples reveal this resistance across industries. Consumer electronics frequently adopt non-repairable designs through soldered components and proprietary tooling [11]. Automotive companies require dealer-specific diagnostic tools that contradict user preferences for accessible maintenance [4]. Software companies implement forced obsolescence through compatibility breaks that prioritize recurring revenue over user productivity. Organizations built around these models resist UX adoption because authentic user research would reveal preferences that conflict with their revenue dependencies.

Despite this, successful implementations demonstrate that authentic user-centered design delivers measurable competitive advantages when conditions align. Design thinking helps organizations overcome cognitive biases that typically impede innovation [10]. Notable examples include GE Healthcare's 90% improvement in pediatric Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI) patient satisfaction [1], IBM's 75% reduction in development time [2], Apple's market leadership via emotional connection [13], and Netflix's transition to streaming driven by personalized UX [5]. However, these successes required comprehensive cultural transformation initiatives.

IV. RECOMMENDATIONS FOR AUTHENTIC IMPLEMENTATION

Presenting HCD to organizational leadership requires rejecting several counterproductive accommodation strategies. Organizations should avoid translating design impact purely into traditional business language or minimizing the cultural change required. This perpetuates the dangerous illusion that design thinking provides equivalent results through different processes without fundamental transformation.

Authentic implementation requires acknowledging that HCD is a distinct business strategy. It

trades short-term efficiency for long-term market position through superior user relationships and systematic advocacy. An assessment of organizational readiness is critical. This involves evaluating executive willingness to act on research findings that conflict with established assumptions, the capacity for sustained investment, and the cultural tolerance for challenging established hierarchies.

V. CONCLUSION

Persistent organizational resistance to authentic HCD reflects a systematic avoidance of approaches that challenge existing power structures. The accommodation strategy of superficial "human-centered theater" only damages the long-term prospects for user-centered approaches. Success requires an honest assessment of organizational readiness and a sustained commitment to profound cultural transformation. Organizations unwilling to make these commitments should focus on operational excellence rather than attempting design implementations that are predisposed to fail.

ACRONYMS

HCD: Human-Centered Design:A user-centered approach to problem-solving that emphasizes empathy, ideation, prototyping, and iterative testing to create innovative solutions 1, 2, 3

UX: User Experience: The overall experience of a person using a product, system, or service, highlighting how easy and pleasing it is to use 1, 2, 3

REFERENCES

[1] Tim Brown. 2008. Design thinking. *Harvard Business Review* 86, 6 (2008), 84–92.

[2] Srikant M. Datar, Amram Migdal, and Penina Hamilton. 2021. *IBM: Design Thinking*. Case 121-007. Harvard Business School. Revised June 2021.

[3] Kimberly D. Elsbach and Ileana Stigliani. 2018. Design Thinking and Organizational Culture: A Review and Framework for Future Research. *Journal of Management* 44, 6 (2018), 2274–2306. doi:10.1177/0149206317744252

[4] European Parliament. 2024. Right to repair: Making repair easier and more appealing to consumers. https://www.europarl.europa.eu/news/en/press-room/20240419IPR20590/right-to-repair-making-repair-easier-and-more-appealing-to-consumers

[5] Ranjay Gulati, A. Ciechanover, and J. Huizinga. 2019. *Netflix: A Creative Approach to Culture and Agility*. Case 420-055. Harvard Business School.

[6] A. Hogan, D. Laufer, D. Truog, W. Willsea, and R. Birrell. 2016. *The Six Steps For Justifying Better UX*. Technical Report. Forrester. https://www.forrester.com/report/The-Six-Steps-For-Justifying-Better-UX/RES117708

[7] Shaun Illingworth. 2025. Lecture Slides, Week 1. (2025). In DTI6102: User Experience Principles and Practices. University of Ottawa.

[8] Shaun Illingworth. 2025. Lecture Slides, Week 2. (2025). In DTI6102: User Experience Principles and Practices. University of Ottawa.

[9] Jon Kolko. 2015. Design Thinking Comes of Age. *Harvard Business Review* 93, 9 (2015), 66–71. https://hbr.org/2015/09/design-thinking-comes-of-age

[10] Jeanne Liedtka. 2018. Why Design Thinking Works. *Harvard Business Review* 96, 5 (2018), 72–79. https://hbr.org/2018/09/why-design-thinking-works

[11] Aaron Perzanowski. 2021. *The Right to Repair: Reclaiming the Things We Own*. Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, UK. doi:10.1017/9781108946926

[12] Giles Slade. 2006. *Made to break: Technology and obsolescence in America*. Harvard University Press, Cambridge, MA. https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctvjhzqd7

[13] Stefan H. Thomke and B. Feinberg. 2009. *Design Thinking and Innovation at Apple*. Case 609-066. Harvard Business School. Revised June 2024.